# An Adventure in Adulthood

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37023760.

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Not Rated

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Multi

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Original Work, She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

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# An Adventure in Adulthood

by CasiopeanQueen

Summary

THIS WAS A SHE RA FAN FIC - WHAT IF CATRA AND ADORA BROKE UP AND SHE GOT WITH SCORPIA
But then IT Evolved into something new and boy oh boy it is something different now.

This tale follows Hailey (Catra) who is in her first year of University. Dealing with the grief of being dumped by her gorgeous brilliant blond GF/ex best friend, Hailey is trying to reconstruct her sense of self by returning to fantasy. Writing is safe and comfortable for Hailey until all of a sudden it becomes the most dangerous thing she has ever done.
The power of her pen on the page has made her a sensation among some circles, a prized pupil among her Professor's selective inner circle but most importantly it has made her interesting to the person she is into... Only one problem with being mysterious is now she has to keep up the mystery.

# Chapter 1

Chapter 1: Stories
Hailey:
It was only the third week of September but the rain cascading from the sky made the day feel like dreary November. Thunder cracked in the distance as five wide-eyed faces stared intensely at the twenty-sided die spinning restlessly on the table. No die had any right to spin for that long, but when it finally came to rest on the table the numbers 19 were barely visible before the table erupted into roars and cheers. Papers covered in detailed maps of fantastic lands and carefully drawn diagrams of ancient runes were blown from the table in a gust of wind as Maddie jumped to her feet and climbed on top of the rickety dining room chair.

With her arm stretched to the yellow and dusty ceiling light above, she cried "I cast Hell-Fire Rebuke!", and slammed a set of 6-sided dice on the table. One sailed into the corner of the room before ricocheting under the table while the other bounced hollowly off Hailey's mug of soda before coming up a 4. Maddie cheered as Regan dove under the table to retrieve the second die, simultaneously hitting their head off the corner of the scratched wooden table and standing heavily on Abb's foot.

"Fuck, Rae" cursed Abbs as the red-head pulled both her knees up to her chin before noticing her friend slumped forward on the linoleum "Oh Shit, Are you alright?" Regan pushed their glasses up into their short dark hair and buried their face firmly in one hand. In the other they valiantly held up the second die. "It's a Three " escaped, muffled through the palm of their hand as they leaned their head back against the seat of the chair they had been sitting on moments before.

Hailey let out a very tight breath. She knew that having both her childhood friends and her new friends in one room would be a

nightmare, but frankly she had not prepared herself for just how rowdy the situation had become.

“Guys, let's calm it down, my roommate is going to kill me if someone dies in our kitchen.” Maddie gave her an abashed smile at least, her freckled face turning nearly the same shade as the faded red hoodie she wearing. But any shadow of remorse was replaced with a grin when A.J piped up.

“Isn’t a little bit of stress-relieving bloodshed exactly what we are here for through?”His cocky smile made Hailey dread the tension headache she was going to have when this was all over.
“Not mine please” came Regan’s groan from under the table. Abb’s leaned over to help them up, her ginger ponytail falling in her face as she hauled her roommate back into their chair.

AJ and Maddie were whispering conspiratorially about spells and deity totems. Hailey found it oddly comforting to see, as much as it worried her for the future of her expertly crafted villains. It had been the better half of a decade since she had been close with AJ and Maddie, not since they were in Middle School. Some things never changed though, and one of those constants was that the moment AJ and Maddie were in a room together, the two shy kids from the back of the class became an untamable force of chaotic energy. It was weird to know them this many years later. Maddie had definitely changed. The girl who was convinced she was a cat well past the point where people considered it cute and into the breach of ‘ I don’t know if she is alright’ had forsaken her cat ears and replaced them with an almost encyclopedic knowledge of true crime facts and forensic statistics. If ever Hailey had to hide a body, she knew where she would turn first, that is if Maddie was capable of avoiding bringing up murder in casual conversation. Even if she was shy at first, Maddie was an insatiable social force with absolutely zero filter and the heart of an excitable great dane puppy.

A.J. on the other hand was the polar opposite. Hailey and A.J. had been friendly before Maddie completed their trifecta, but even the closted people to A.J. in the world could only usually get about 100 words out of him a day. Hailey wouldn't go as far as to say A.J. blossomed into a gregarious butterfly, but the lanky blond boy had at least trimmed his hair enough that when he chose to make eye contact it was now possible.

Honestly, Hailey felt bad for Regan, and for Abbs tonight. She hadn't known either of them for very long. She had met Abbs through the Queer Qampus meetings hosted through her school only a few weeks ago. Hailey imagined that when she had asked if Abbs wanted to join her little D&D campaign that she probably hadn't been expecting Maddie and A.J.'s antics.

Regan had perhaps a little more warning about the chaos to come. After sitting with Hailey in Creative Writing for a few weeks they had brought up their love of fantasy. Hailey had been mulling it around for a while but when she brought up D&D and Regan had been thrilled at the prospect of joining. It had been really nice to see someone else's eyes light up with that same boundless nostalgic joy that Hailey herself had for this little game. And she would admit to herself and no one else that perhaps it was that radiant spark of enthusiasm she saw in Regan that pushed her to work a little harder to get this campaign off the ground. Either way, having all her friends in one cramped kitchen for a night was definitely turning out to be an experience.
Hailey picked up her own dice, made some rolls and did some mental math as she clicked through the tabs open on the laptop in front of her.

"Ok Maddie," she said, "as you, er Yaza, turn the corner she fires 2 bolts of fire into the minotaur, it stumbles back but is still standing." Hailey reached forward and cleared some of the dislodged papers off of her battle map before sketching a brief outline of the cellar in which her friend's champions found themselves. She threw in some bubble shapes for boxes and junk in the corners of the dry erase room before setting down a token for the recently toasted minotaur.

“Bullshit,” cursed Maddie, thumping her fist on the table so hard that the minotaur keeled over from the shock. “Are you sure this is a level appropriate encounter? WE’VE BEEN AT THIS FOR HOUUURS!” She moaned through a mouth full of popcorn.

A.J. elbowed Maddie in the side playful “I feel like if the Bull was Shitting we’d have an easier time at killing it.”
Rolling her eyes at AJ, Hailey slid out from her chair and her little barricade of notes and manuals. “Hey I am not the one who told you to solve all your problems with violence, just remember that when his friends show up and destroy you.”

“THERE ARE MORE OF THEM?” came Maddie’s gasp of dismay from across the table. Hailey ignored Maddie for the moment. She was way more concerned about Regan, who was still holding their head in their hands like if they didn’t keep it in place it might just roll away. She waved her hand absently at Maddie and AJ before saying “Make a DC 15 perception check to see if Monitor has friends. Abbs was already standing beside Regan, trying to get them to take their hand off their face long enough for Abbs assess the damages.
“Jeeze, Abbs, I am ok, I’m not even bleeding” Muttered Regan as Hailey scooted past, finally dropping their hand from her face; “Look, no blood, so there is no way I am going to let you practice your nursing on me!”.

Abbs let out at halfhearted “Hey” but looked a little less worried about them.
From the table the sounds of AJ and Maddie making dice rolls and shuffling papers came to an end and Maddie let out a gasp. “Uh hey pal, you look like you’re going to get a nasty bruise” Regan forced a smile but it couldn’t really hide the massive welt beginning to form just above their left eyebrow. Hailey winced at

the sight of it.
“Here, let me grab you some ice.” Walking across to the rest of the kitchen, she opened the freezer and dug around for something suitable.
Student fridges were rarely full of ‘healthy’ food, but Hailey was more concerned about having food at all this week. Her Scholarship money still hadn’t dropped but she knew somewhere behind the pizza pockets and bags of marked-down bread products….hmmm… there!

“Ok I have Corn or Green Beans, what would you prefer?” she said, pulling both the plastic bags from the freezer.
“Oh, gimme that corn please” Regan called from across the table.
“Head’s up, Abbs” called Hailey, before carefully tossing the bag across the kitchen. Ever the athlete, Abbs caught the bag perfectly before passing it to Regan, who was perched gingerly back on their chair.

The kitchen was really cramped with 5 people in it. Heck, Hailey only owned 4 chairs. She was glad AJ didn’t mind using her office chair. But some sacrifices always had to be made. Student life was never supposed to be glamorous.

Stuffing the Green Beans back in the freezer, Hailey shuffled back the long way behind AJ and Maddie before settling back down at the head of the table.
While Abbs tended to Regan, Hailey gathered up some of her papers and notes. It has been a long day and she hadn’t yet had a chance to go through all of her player’s characters and integrate their backstories into her campaign. That would be something for later tonight. Right now though, she could make sure that all of her players had a chance to engage with the combat. Maddie’s Warlock, Yaza, had rushed ahead and was throwing Hell-Fire balls left, right and center. Hailey had known Maddie would probably rush into things like she did when they played D&D when they

were kids, which is why she had paired Yaza with Regan's classic knight in shining armor, Sylas. AJ was playing a suave and charismatic half-elf sorceress named Tarhan and Hailey felt that the dynamic between Yaza and Tarhan could get competitive, both because they were the only magic users in the party and because Maddie and AJ always liked to one-up each other, even when they were all in grade-school.
Abb's had decided to play a Wear-Cat bard, who abandoned his family's criminal enterprise to make a name for himself in the big city. Hailey wasn't super sure how to work that in yet but she was starting to come up with a plan.

A finger descended into Hailey's view and poked her firmly in the cheek just below her glasses. Looking up, she saw Abbs, Maddie and AJ all looking at her expectantly.
"Uh sorry, I was completely not present, what was the question?" She asked. AJ pushed his blond hair out of his face and pushed up his glasses before saying.
"Tarhan got a 19 on perception for the Minotaur's Friend situation. Unfortunately Yaza definitely doesn't know if Minitours even have friends." Looking over to Maddie, Hailey raised an eyebrow, "Natural 1?."

"No, just a 2" came Maddie's groan as she pulled her red headphones over her ears and the hood of her red hoodie on top. Hailey snorted, "Yeah Yaza is unsure if the minotaur has friends and if they are joining this shindig, however," turning to AJ she continued" Tarhan is pretty sure there are some goblins around the corner that will come into view next round."

Hailey was about to go back to her notes when AJ continued. "Um…. I hate to be a party pooper, but I was just wondering if you wanted to call it here for the night and pick it up again next week? If I don't get home soon I won't have time to get as much done on my project as I want to tonight, aaand my parents might

get pissed”
Hailey looked at the time on her phone, 10:24PM on a Saturday. Shit, she worked in the morning too. Letting out a long sigh, she nodded her head. It was a little ambitious to get through character creation and the whole first encounter of this campaign in a single night anyways.

“Yeah, honestly, I am wiped, I work pretty early so I should probably get some sleep too”.
Maddie looked up from her character sheet with a start, “Wha..Noo I want to finish kicking this furry – cow – ass!”
Hailey was about to try and convince her otherwise when Abbs piped up.

“Yeah, I should probably get Regan home and make sure their not too concussed, and if we head out now we can make the next bus” Reganmumbled a half-hearted “I’m fine, Jeeze” from under the corn but it seemed like everyone was on their way out. Hailey nodded, “Sounds good. We can pick up here next week! If you want you can leave all your character sheets with me and finish up any adding anything we didn’t get to today.”

The next few minutes were filled with scraping chairs and farewells. Maddie and AJ headed out first with a hollered “See Ya” as they ran down the rainy street towards the university. Abbs and Regan stayed behind, waiting for the bus to come into view at the end of the street. Abbs explained the upcoming ‘Taco Tuesday ’ event that Queer Qampus was putting on in the coming weeks. Hailey was happy just to have a moment to chat with her friend, but her mind was wandering. She was pretty sure she was saying all the right “Yeahs” and “uhuhs” and she was mostly looking at Abbs, until Regan tapped her on the shoulder and passed back the corn. At this point they looked less bruised, if still exhausted. Their dark hair was plastered to their face thanks to the condensation from the frozen corn and their gray green eyes looked happy just watching Abbs as she spoke and just as Hailey

realized she was probably staring too long, Regan looked up to meet her gaze.

"Bus!" Regan's eyes snapped back to Abbs who was pulling on her varsity jacked. The two of them said their good-byes and sprinted half a block up the street to the bus shelter. Hailey waited in the dark and cluttered entryway until she saw the bus pull up and her two friends get on. The hallway was a mess of shoes across the matt and coats hung on the wall-hooks. She noticed something odd on the ground by the door and Hailey bent down to pick it up. A black toque, Regan's hat. She tucked the hat into the back pocket of her jeans.

As she turned away from the door she let out a huge sigh. Honestly, things could have gone a lot worse. One major bodily injury was pretty standard for her attempts at managing social situations. Picking her way across the shoe-filled vestibule in two big steps, Hailey walked back into the Kitchen and began putting things away. She tossed the corn back into the freezer before sitting back down at the head of the table. She made some quick notes in her book about player positions and turn order, before gathering up all her papers and books into a stack on top of her laptop. She tossed the miniature character models she had been using into a pencil case and then picked up the rogue popcorn kernels and mugs of soda from across the table. Some simple dishes later the dimly lit kitchen was passably clean, at least to the point where her roommate would not give her meaningful looks or passive-aggressive sticky notes, so Hailey picked up her stack of papers and her laptop, placed them on the desk-chair that AJ had vacated nearly an hour before and retreated down the short hallway into her room wheeling the chair in front of her.

The apartment wasn't much, just a kitchen, bathroom and a pair of bedrooms and the front door nook, but there was no place that Hailey loved more in the world than her own bedroom, so the shabbiness of the apartment didn't really bother her. The walls were all the same shade of used-to-be-white, but she had done

her best to bring as much of 'home' as she could with her when she had finally gotten out of her mother's place.
Pushing open the door to her room, she shoved the chair over to the desk before closing the door behind her.

Her bed was on the left, just a mattress on the floor butted up against the far corner of the room, but she had enough throw pillows and blankets to make it look like a nest of warmth and comfort. Beside the bed was a narrow curtained window. The view was nothing special, just the road and some bushes, but the natural light was nice in the day. Her desk was right under the window with a row of books lining the full length of it. Stacks of textbooks and note-books also sat on the floor in neatly organized stacks. Above the desk to the right of the window, twinkling lights crisscrossed along the wall, held in place thumb tacks and some artfully chosen pictures.

The closet at the back of the room was where Hailey turned now. The closet with its ever-broken sliding doors was full of boxes and bins. The far right had enough room for Hailey to hang some of her clothes, but the rest of her clothes and possessions sat in boxes she had packed back in April. She threw the dnd stuff on top of an old rubber-maid container that held all her winter coats and moved her laptop from the chair to her desk. She took the hat and tossed it onto the top of her row of books. She had to text Regan about that before she forgot. She needed to shower and then get to sleep, because Hailey knew she would have a long day tomorrow.

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After her shower, Hailey toweled off her hair and walked back into her bedroom. Pulling on some new socks, an old t-shirt and some sleep-shorts from the closet, she got dressed and threw the towel on to a hook in the closet. She decided to write out some of the
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events of the game-session. Honestly, Hailey was thrilled that she had been able to re-connect with AJ and Maddie since coming to Monroe U. It had been hard when they had been separated at the end of 8th grade, and the years in between had sure as hell not been easy either but seeing them during Orientation Week had given Hailey a much needed sense of connection. As a part-time student, she sometimes felt like she only had one foot in the door. But she was committed that she was going to stay here. It hadn't been an easy choice to come here, even after April had decided not to.

Even after she left you.

She faltered; she wasn't about to think of April now. Not now when she had come so far without her and had made friends and was doing so well. Hailey caught herself hyperventilating and tried to control her breathing. Opening up her laptop she threw on some music to calm herself down. A little chaos in her ears would help her stay focused. She threw on her headphones and focused on the sounds until she could breathe calmly again.

She was not going to think about April.
Hailey began going over her notes from the session. Typing out back-story and connections. Annotating some of her planned plot points and making some of the villains a bit more 'personal'. The plot for her campaign was still not fully formed but as she made notes, the story seemed to unfold in front of her. Grabbing her friend's character-sheets she began going over her notes and their back-stories. Everything was clicking into place to become an exciting story. Hailey was itching to share her ideas with someone, so after hammering out the over - arching plot of the campaign to a more stable point, she saved her progress and opened up her Blog.

She had run a small-time D&D / Creative Writing blog for years, ever since "She-Who-Must-Not-Be-Named" had set her up with one at the start of high school. She would throw up short stories here and on her Tumblr (Create a fake social media?) every so often, along with prompt ideas and writing advice. Since the end

of high school, she had racked up a small following, 2500 people, who seemed to like her stories and tips. She usually only posted one-offs, scenes and the occasional inappropriate fanfiction. But Hailey felt like the change in pace could be good.
She sat down, grabbed her bottle of water from beside her bed and considered her computer screen as she took a drink.

Damn, that was some good water considering it had been in the bottle for days now. Finishing the bottle she resigned to minor dehydration and began to type. The story didn't really flow at first. There were lots of backtracks and changes, but that is how it usually started and before she knew it her fingers were flying across the keys like the story had written itself already and it was just waiting for her hands to catch up and actualize it. The backgrounds and the motivations of Sylas and Yaza seemed so real to her and she almost let out a tear at the pain Yaza must have gone through with the loss of her village. She shuddered to think of how Sylas felt as he betrayed the faith of the whole kingdom. She supposed he figured he was giving them hope and that he did what he thought was right.

Tarhan and Yaza really did conflict on a fundamental level but they were also both steadfast and loyal and as she wrote, Hailey found there was great potential there for a friendship deeper than oceans or a rivalry that ended only in a magical battle to the death. But even as the possibilities of the story opened up in front of her, she felt like something was missing. She hadn't even introduced Talius yet but she was faltering now. Only after an hour did she realize that her music had stopped long ago and she was just listening to empty air as she tried to find the words to finish off the chapter.
And then it was done. It wasn't perfect, but nothing really was. Satisfied that the writing was good enough for the moment. Hailey saved it and posted it to her Blog and threw the link up on her Tumblr. Glancing at the clock she mentally cursed herself, it was nearly 1am and she most definitely worked at 8am tomorrow.

Berating herself for her own poor life choices, Hailey closed her computer. Standing up from her chair, she dug her toes into the carpet and stretched up, feeling her back and arms stretch and crack like she was a centuries old hermit living in a hovel in the woods or just a university student with terrible posture. She walked across the carpet to the door, opened it and rounded the corner into the bathroom. In the washroom she took off her glasses and bent down to splash her face with cool water. Pulling up her shirt to dry her face, she looked at her blurred reflection in the mirror. Two dark spaces for her eyes stared back at her from below a messy blue halo. She supposed she really looked like some kind of alien like this. Pushing her glasses back onto her face, she fumbled around for her toothbrush and toothpaste.

The exhaustion of the day was finally catching up to her now. Hours of homework, prepping and playing D&D had left dark circles under her already dark eyes. Her hair was starting to fade already, ocean blue turning to sea-weed and swamp-witch green faster than she would have liked. Closing her eyes, Hailey finished brushing her teeth. Opening her eyes after she finished, the exhaustion on her face was reflected all too obviously to her. She could probably think of what her mother would say about her staying up this late on a work night, about her responsibilities and expectations. But those thoughts weren't going to help her get to sleep. Flicking off the bathroom light, she stepped into the hallway.

As she looked up, she saw her roommate Bree coming in from a smoke. The skinny blond always seemed to smell like marijuana and vanilla and only seemed to own track pants and hoodies. Hailey gave the other girl a half smile before slipping into her bedroom and closing the door.

It wasn't that Hailey didn't like her roommate. As far as roommates could be concerned Bree was pretty good. Quiet, Respectful, Clean, Smoked outside like 90% of the time. Hailey just really valued solitude. And it seemed like with all the things

going on there was never enough time to just be alone anymore. Between her friends, University and her job, there was always something pulling her in one direction or another. She would have much preferred to live alone. It wasn't that Bree got on her nerves, but it was not like living with some random girl had been part of her plan. She had a good plan, but April had made that change for her.

Groaning under her breath, Hailey turned to close her bedroom door and leaned her head against the wall.
April wasn't welcome in her head. She wasn't welcome in her heart either, but that didn't stop the every insidious thoughts that crept into Hailey's head.
How was she? Did she care about how hard it was for Hailey without her?

Probably not. Hailey had a good plan for how this year was going to go, and this was decidedly not it. But she was here now, and she was not going back.
She hit the light and stumbled through the darkness to her bed before crawling under her mountain of blankets and pillows. When she was under a comfortable amount of pressure, she reached up and grabbed her phone, swiping to unlock it.

1:15 AM Sunday September 26th.
She had a message from Maddie to her and AJ's recently revived group chat, saying they had gotten home ok. Hailey opened it and just sent a heart emoji to the group. Regan had also sent her a message.
Regan : "Hey, I am so sorry about earlier! I hope the table is doing ok lol. Honestly I am doing ok, Abbs just worries over everything lmao"
Regan: "But yeah, I really had fun tonight, I totally see where all your creativity comes from for Barveson's class! Lookin' forward to next time"

She snorted. It has been one time. Barveson had asked the class for short-story ideas and Hailey had rattled off something she had used before with a few alterations.He had written the plot arch on

the bord and spent the rest of the class using it as an example for their lecture on narrative structure. Apart from being mind-numbingly embarrassing for Hailey to be called out like that, she was also acutely aware that there were probably half a dozen people in that class that now thought she was a total faker, using internet-blogs to impress her professors like some enterprising teacher's pet.
Pulling the phone charger from where it was hidden behind her bed, Hailey plugged in her phone before typing out a reply to Regan.
Hailey:

"Hey, no I am the one who should be sorry, my table has a thirst for blood lol! But I'm glad that you are doing a little better now".
"And don't get me started on Barverson, I literally can never speak again in his class!"

"But yeah, I am glad you and Abbs got home ok! Will I see you on Monday for Lit-Hist 1001?"
Hailey closed her texting app and opened her clock. Setting an alarm for 6:45, 6:50, 7am and 7:15 before flicking through to her Tambr app. Seeing she had a few likes and comments on the story she had just posted, she smiled to herself. She knew a handful of her followers in person, but many of them she only knew from their handles. Since things had gone south in her home life, keeping up with her blog had always given her a sense of consistency, and even if she knew it was a little unhealthy, her followers made her feel valued, and that feeling pushed a lot of her content-creation these days.
A text from Regan flashed at the top of her phone.

She clicked it and read:
"Sure thing, bright and early. Gotta love those Monday 9am classes, ammi right?"
"And don't beat yourself up over it, you legit had a good idea, plus don't they say, Imitation is the highest form of flattery ?"
Hailey : "sure they say that but I am pretty sure they didn't mean

me stealing prompts off Tabler”
Hailey : “Oh btw I found your hat on the floor, ill bring it Mon! ”
Regan “Don’t sell yourself too short hun”
Regan: “Oh heck that’s a relief!! I thought I dropped it on the bus XD”
Hailey froze for a second. Regan was a fan of nick-names and endearments but “Hun”…. Hailey wasn’t sure if she was ready to acknowledge the shock of adrenaline that shot through her arms as she closed her phone and stuck it under her pillow. After a moment, after her heart had calmed down and would let her brain do the talking, she pulled the phone back up and opened the texting app again.
Hailey : “Lol, ill try I guess. Anyhow, I gtg to sleep, work :P”
“G’night”
Regan : “Night you!”

Hailey locked her phone and slid it out from the covers and up to rest on her desk.
It didn’t take her very long to fall asleep. But her dreams were restless and filled with fiery battles, gleaming swords and a princess with a face that was all too familiar and far too heartbreaking. When her alarm went off in the morning, she silenced it, and then silenced the second and third as well. It was only the panic instilled by the 4th alarm that launched her from her bed into action. It was a long and tiring day ahead of her.

# Dawn Shyrn Lost

Chapter Summary

Sylas is granted a quest - And Oh Boy Does He Not Want To Do It.

Chapter Notes

EVERY SECOND CHAPTER Takes place in the dnd campaign DM'ed by our intrepid heroine. This chapter is backstory to Regan's character.

CONTENT WARNING - A little bit of PTSD with a slice of near death experience

For reference:
Sylas = Human fighter. Played by Regan. Once wielded a powerful magic sword but whoopsie he broke that shit. Much PTSD and shame as well as imposter syndrome.

Tarhan - Half-elven Sorceress and Seer - Played by AJ -- Powerful magician but often her power has been overlooked as being a result of her elven heritage and that she was bestowed the gift of foresight. - Experiences minor fantasy racism

Yaza -- Vampire Warlock with Animal Companion -Played by Maddie- Vicious and powerful warrior who has been a member of the rebels for years as they have tried to carve out a chunk of habitable land from Kastralorn to found a colony for displaced magical beasts.

Talius -- Wear-cat rogue who refuses to steal and aims to become a bard... Played by Abbs --- he has no real musical experience and his family has completely disowned him for giving up his comfortable life of crime to live like a beggar on the streets with nothing but a ukulele

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pushed his dark hair from in front of his eyes instead turned his attention to the small army of young squires that had come running to meet him and his entourage.
If Sylas was to keep ahead of this fight he would need to keep his mind in the moment and not dwell on the past, for the sake of his honour, for his people and for his kingdom.
Breaking into his most radiant and genuine forced smile, Sylas dismounted his steed with one smooth motion. Passing the rains to the nearest squire, he nodded and waved to the crowd of young maidens who had gathered by the arch to observe his arrival. He supposed to them it would be very exciting day to bookend a tumultuous week; it was not every day that Lord Sylas of Armhad, Destroyer of Hellspawn and Champion of Kastralon exited his humble keep to walk amongst the nobility. At least, not any longer.
But as the kingdom's foremost knight and most eligible bachelor, it was Sylas' time and place to stand here. So here he stood, arrayed in the shining armor of his forefathers and wearing the Cloak of the Champion, smiling his hollow reassurances to the people of Kastralon. Aids rushed to attend Sylas' household and bringing his possessions into the keep proper, while squires lead away the horses. Sylas stood what he deemed far enough away from the maidens of the keep to keep at bay the onslaught of greetings and introductions that he felt victim to at every banquet, ball and council since the day he rose to the order of champion.
Just then the crowed gathered in the square began to part, as Alisus, the portly steward of castle Elenvol, descended the stairs from the Royal Hall into the courtyard. Alisus had known Sylas since he was no more than a boy, and it was clear from the look in his eyes as he approached that he barely regarded Sylas to me more than that same child now. His bow was overly formal and he greeted Sylas and the gathered crowed with what could have been an impertinent tone, if Sylas had reserves enough of energy to guess.
"Good day and welcome to you Lord Sylas of Armhad, on behalf of Queen Kasirda of Kastralon and the Siamors, I am honored to welcome you to Elenvol, your arrival has been greatly anticipated by Her Majesty and the council of Elenvol." He paused now and

addressed the crowed,
"Ladies and Gentlemen of the Household, It is my great honor to present the Champion of the Kasterlon to our Exalted Queen and Resplendent princess this very afternoon. Our Lord of Armhad, dauntless in the face of vengeful beasts of corrupt mind and stalwart in opposition to the fiercest of dark magics, has been summoned to serve her majesty once again and to rid our land of the foul and craven beasts that have enacted this pitiful attempt to deface the glorious seat of our great Lady, to cast shadows upon her reign. But these gutless and inconsequential acts will not hinder our illustrious Queen and her uncompromisable aim to bring The Wilds (Better Name Pending) and the vicious beasts that inhabit them under the protection of her Kingdom and into her loving embrace."
Although cordial, the steward's tone could not belie the beads of sweat on his brow nor the roiling nest of anxious snakes that had taken up residence just under Sylas' s heart. Despite the praise Alisus had just given him before the crowed, Sylas could see from the man's demeanor that he was not as welcome here as he would have hoped. And worse, that whatever had happened here was far more harrowing than the rumors, which had had danced tavern to tavern all across the kingdom, had let on. Whatever had happened to the castle had been more than just a random attack, the state of the Dawn-Shyrn tower was confirmation enough of that.
Sylas supposed the decision was made for him. The one he had known he was going to have to make again since the moment he saw the Hellbeast. He made this choice of his own free will the first time, a young fool thirsty for glory and the fame of the sword.
But gods above, if only he could choose this time.
Time was a cruel thing and experience doubly so. Sylas could see his fate now as clearly as if he had already walked the path. Perhaps because he had.
For the second time, Sylas was going to be sent to die for his kingdom, for some greater cause. Again, his Queen had called on him to go to his death for glory and for her honor.
But if Sylas' legacy was to be one of theatrics and tragedy, he may

as well make it one of the better songs of woe. A legend to be passed down by the lips of bards to the hollow eyes of men of war in the eves before a battle, or one whispered by the fireside to the wonderous eyes of children in the safety of their towns and villages. A story of a shinning knight who lost his life for the freedom of the kingdom.
Sylas let his face fall into wry smile. Someone who he used to be would have loved this notion of dying with glory for a cause. But if going through the motions bought him some time, than he supposed that would need to be good enough.
Nodding solemnly to the steward, Sylas turned to the crowded and held his gauntleted fist to the sky. He addressed the bright eyed youths and the fluttering silk fans of the ladies before him.
"People of the kingdom of Kasterlon," Sylas shouted with all the suave confidence he could muster, "Do not let fear touch your hearts, for I am here to keep it at bay! You may have heard my name on the lips of bards and in the drinking songs soldiers, for it is I, Sylas of Armhad, Destroyer of the Hellspawn of the Northern Wilds. Our magnificent Queen, as gracious as she is courageous, as summoned me here to strike fear into the hearts of those cursed-creatures that threaten our cities and destroy our fields. Let your worries wane, because…." Now reaching around to unbuckle the sword on his back, Sylas unsheathed the blade and held it high for all the crowd to see. "As your champion, I am here to eclipse them all. I give you the word of the Champion that I will fight back the darkness and guide us into the light of day." As he drew his sword, the crowd undulated in a communal scramble backward and Sylas cracked his first genuine smile of the day.
He must look hideously cliched at this moment. Sylas wondered if any of them genuinely believed the pomp and show of contemporary chivalry. He imagined they must, otherwise who would put up with it all.
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As Alisus' aids and his own household staff saw to his possessions as, Sylas was led by the Alisus up the keep, escorted by a company of fair maidens and foolish youths who no doubt saw in him proof of their own potential to one day wield a sword for the kingdom. Sylas remembered the brazen foolishness and gall he
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had at their age. Even if fairly few years had passed him by since he was but a squire himself, Sylas felt the gap between him and the people he had sworn to protect grew wider with each passing year. To these bright faces he may have been a paragon of strength and proof of the triumphs of the kingdom over the treacherous magical beasts of the Wilds, but Sylas had seen enough people in the stocks to know that these future lords and ladies would turn on him as quickly as common folk turn on the fay and wear-beasts that lived among them, if they descovered the secret he carried with him.

Mounting the stairs two at a time, Sylas made his excuses to the crowd as he followed the steward into the atrium of the keep. The great room was lit only by an opening in the cealing through which sunlight poured like rain onto the great stones of the floor. In the center of the room where the light danced the brightest was a pool of water that reflected the sun in lazy whisps across the beams of the wooden rafters. Sylas hurried after Alisus as the man moved quickly along the outskirts of the room, bypassing the great wooden doors opposite where they had entered. When the last of the staring faces had left them behind, Sylas cleared his throat. The sound carried in the stone atrium. Even in the day, the eerie stillness of the castle always unsettled him. Like the whole edifice was parched on some great beast ready to swallow him whole.

Catching himself, Sylas tried again as they crossed the great to the rear of the hall.

"Alisus, I know that I will no doubt speak to the queen as soon as I am settled in my chambers, but first, I must know from you what has happened here?"

At first the steward continued towards the right hand corridor at the rear of the atrium, making no motion to answer, but then he turned to Sylas. It was plain to see that as much as Sylas himself had put on a performance in the courtyard, the Steward had been masking the gravity of the situation[1] with the skill and poise of only the most proficient retainers.

The fear was apparent in his eyes as he spoke, voice barely more than a whisper.

"It…. It is not my place to tell of the events of the night of the

new moon. The Krasid- ah, Her Majesty, will address you directly and immediately. There is no time for delay, dare I say we have already dallied too long." The man's tone took the snakes coiled in Sylas' gut and replaced them with a hole straight to hell, but he continued forward following the Steward as he turned and continued towards the corridor branching from the far corner of the hall. Alisus led him deeper into the bowels of the castle. The corridor they had taken was unfamiliar to Sylas, despite the many years he lived at castle Elenvol in his youth. The passage began as the mortar and stone masonry of the kingdom's best craftsmen, broken up by frequent wall sconces and tapestries of a myriad of colours depicting banquets and victories of the late husband of the Queen, His Royal Highness Xanciar First Duke of Kastralon.

Sylas had never known the man, but the stories of his decisiveness and cunning military tactics in the second Wilds War had been a favorite of during his education. First Duke Xanciar had lost his life as the wars drew to a close, but his legacy served as a foundation for the Kastralionian military to this day. Sylas wondered in vague but humorous way if the story of his glorious death at the hands of some ravenous magical beast would also inspire legions to take up arms against the wild creatures and magical beasts of the Wilds.

Soon the corridor began to slope downwards and the damp chill air washed over Sylas as the brickwork changed from the granite of the new castle to the perfectly chiseled limestone of the Last Kingdom. Each perfect slab interlocking with the next, making this corridor a perfect cage that Sylas wondered if he would ever come out of.

In front of him, Alisus seemed to be growing nervous. The man checked behind him more frequently now and Sylas could see the sweat beading on his brow again. The descent of the incline likely had less to do with the Stewards' sweat then the horrifying stories of what had occurred here in this castle 100 years ago.

Never one for the ancient history books, Sylas knew his knowledge of the founding of Kasterlon and the time before the Wilds Wars was more myth than reality. But if there was even a grain of truth in the story, then Sylas wouldn't have been

surprised if the limestone of the Last Kingdom were to give way to catacombs of human bone before their journey was complete.
In hushed voices around fires and in taverns after the Bards had long exhausted their supply of news and gossip, stories of the Fall of the Last Kingdom were shared between stiff drinks and solemn silences.
As the corridor turned and twisted ever downward, Sylas remembered the worst of those stories. How the Last Kingdom, where the creatures of Magic and the Humans had lived in harmony, was ravaged from the inside out. How man and beast alike turned on each other and were consumed by a ravenous darkness that drove man to kill and magic to feed. Once in a century the Dawn-Shyrn was born to cast the insidious darkness from the kingdom for the next generation. But at the end of the Last Kingdom, the creatures of magic were tempted by the power that the darkness could bring them, and savagely turned on the Humans of the Last Kingdom to destroy the Dawn-Shyrn.
The Valiant Princess of the Last Kingdom, Dawn-Shyrn of her time, sacrificed herself to cast out the darkness in the ancient rite of protection, but her death destroyed the alliances between the kingdoms and man and magic. In the intervening decades of chaos and savagery before Kastralon was founded, much of the lore and scripture surrounding the Dawn-Shyrn was lost. But it was evident to Sylas that contrary to what he had learned through stories and legends, not every trace of the Last Kingdom had been destroyed by agents of Dark Magic. Some of the castle of the Last Kingdom clearly remained here, hiding below Kastralon itself.
Sylas knew that not all of the myths surrounding the fall of the Last Kingdom were founded in fact, but he knew the corrupting power of the darkness all too well. And he truly believed the creatures who festered could raze a castle nearly to the ground.
When Sylas closed his eyes, on nights where the moon was dark or the fire in his chambers had died out, he could still hear the guttural howl of his Hellbeast. He could feel his arms trembling as he held his broken sword up for the last time. And even now as his feet tread slowly forward on the cold stones in front of him, he was still there in the Northern Woodlands. He was always in the woodlands.

Every night he stood in front of the village as the flames devoured homes around him. And every night he heard the horrific screams the creature made, screams that drowned out the chanting the warlocks and the roar of the flames. The screams were louder than his own heartbeat in his ears and they filled him more than the breath in his lungs. And that is when he knew he was going to die.

When he tried to run, it would always happen faster. The reverberating growl would pierce him first, then the horrendous stench of the creature would blow over him, he would look down and see those hideous claws rip through him from the behind, feel his own soul be torn from his chest and devoured even as his heart gave its final beats.

When he fought it, it took longer. Every ounce of his strength would leave him before the end. Maybe he would slow it down. It would stagger back and give a few more lost souls time to escape from the flames and into the night. But the end was always the same no matter how it started. His sword was shattered. And without his sword he would always die.

The breath caught in his throat as Sylas tried to calm his racing heart, to wrench himself back into reality. He could hear the breath hissing from between his clenched teeth and he could see the dark of the corridor in front of him, even if it felt to him to be across a great ocean.

He would not unravel here in this corridor, he would not unravel before the queen, before his household or his kingdom. He had nothing left now other than his honour as a hero and he refused to lose that. Not now, after everything he had done to keep it secret. To protect the truth.

The truth, that he was powerless now. Not a champion nor a vessel for power.

He was just a man, with a piece of metal and a name he didn’t deserve.

His next step landed heavily and a good 4 inches lower than Sylas had expected. Instinctually he fell into a crouch and reached for the sword on his back.

In times past the act of drawing his weapon would have been as fluid as the movement of his own hands, but the unfamiliar

weapon still weighed on him like an unwanted prosthetic.
Further down the steps, Alisus turned back to him and let out a slight gasp. No doubt Sylas looked unhinged, breathless and uneasy as he was.
He really hated this place.
Easing into a more relaxed stance, he shrugged at the other man before continuing down the steps. If he listened now, Sylas could make out the distant sound of female voices. And as they continued down the well-worn limestone steps into what seemed like an endless serpentine passageway, the voices became clearer and more agitated.
Light drifted up from the foot of the stairs, but it was a sickly blue light that pulsed like Sylas' own unsteady heartbeat.
A shrill voice echoed from the space beyond, and Sylas knew the voice not from where he could place it.
"I cannot tell you more and no seer nor magician of any other creed or practice could tell you any different now. She is alive, that was already known to us, but where she lives is not something I can simply derive from an ancient rock and a parlor trick incantation. I will need to gather the proper supplies and prepare if I am to find her".
The words of the response were lost to Sylas but the second voice he knew far too well. It was the voice of her majesty, Queen Kasirda, and while her words may have been obscured to him, the biting ice of her voice was not.
"No, Your Majesty I do not suggest that at all" the second voice came again, this time with an air of deference.
"I am humbly stating the limits of contemporary spellcraft and my-"
Nearly to the foot of the steps now, Sylas flinched when the Queen's next words echoed forcefully through the corridor around him.
"Silence! It is not your place to have faith or fear, it is yours to do your duty to this kingdom. Was it not the House of Elenvol who protected the Great Seers after the Fall of the Last Kingdom ? Your Kind ," the words were spat with seething contempt that Sylas knew the Queen reserved for those few magic users still in service to the crown " Were all but eradicated, save for the Grace

and Forethought of my father, and now you will serve your purpose. Find her, retrieve her, or you will no longer live in the clemency of my protection."
As Alisus disappeared into the chamber ahead, Sylas peered ahead of him, the eerie blue light casting shadows and calling ghosts into his vision. He stepped forward and felt his stomach drop as his eyes swam with the magnitude of the chamber before him.
Fully spherical in shape, the cavern before Sylas was equal parts unholy and beautiful in its construction. The immaculate masonry of the Last Kingdom was outstripped a thousand-fold by the stone work of this chamber. It was as if the whole world had been snatched by the gods and spread over the walls. Every Mountain range and valley, every shoreline, river valley and gorge was relieved on the walls in stunning and incomparable detail. Sylas' first steps into the room nearly caused him to fall onto his knees as the vertigo of the space washed over him. Below his feet was a miniature shoreline and waves washed up upon it. On his next step Sylas fully believed he would fall into the sea itself, but his feet landed try and remained just above the surface of the land, placed on what must have been the thinnest and purest class ever seen by human eyes. Drawing his eyes from his feet to the room in front of him, he noticed the sphere spinning like a slow unstoppable tide in the center of the room. A dozen bands of silver wider than a man was tall shifted and rotated around the blue pulsing heart of the room. It glowed and beat with an impossible light that made Sylas' chest tight and his eyes water. Not from pain, but from an inexplicable sense of loss and longing. It was like staring at a Moon that had come to earth.
Sylas had not even noticed his feet betray him until he realized, after several seconds, that he had done not but stare at the expanse of the room and the light at its heart until Alisus cleared his throat.
"Lord Sylas of Armhad, Champinon of Kasterlon, has arrived in answer to yours Summons my Queen"
Returning his eyes to the women before him, Sylas regained his senses enough to fall into a deep bow before the Queen. But even as he stared at the ground beneath his feet, he was amazed at

the fine detail and mind bending intricacies of the map on which he was standing. Looking down had given him the bearings he needed, both to compose himself before her majesty and to situate himself on the topography before him. Between his feet was the unmistakable curves of the Athor River and, at the Queen's demand of " Rise" Sylas followed the river with his eyes as he straightened up until they lit upon the familiar peeks and valleys of land surrounding Armhad.
His dumbfounded silence was soon interrupted by Queen Kasirda's disapproving sniff.
"Young Lord, please take your time admiring the floor"
"Your Majesty, forgive my--" Sylas began. "No" the Queen cut him off. "We have no time for formality here sir, nor time to admire the scenery." Gesturing distractedly to the other woman the Queen turned from him towards the light in the heart of the room. Under the blue light, the dark robes the queen wore were a contrast to her almost luminous face and pale locks of hair that flowed down her back. They reminded Sylas of another royal person that he had known, and his heart cowered in shame at her memory. Realizing now that he had not been attending to the conversation at hand, his focus returned to the queen as she spoke.
"-, however, the oracle of Dresilan has long been a trusted ally to the crown. Seer Tarhan of the Order, I present you with your companion, Sylas of Armhad. I trust that you will put aside all-- " and with a disappointed look at Tarhan " differences, in order to complete your mission. I will not accept failure in this matter, which is why I selected you both specifically. You will reclaim her and return her to me so that I may protect this Kingdom, this whole damn continent, from the savage beasts that want to take it from me. They took my husband but they end of days will come before I let them take her from me".
Fear took root in Sylas' gut at the use of the word "Her", but he nodded to the queen and turned his attention to the woman at her side.
With a curt bow, he took in her appearance. She was very tall, her long blue robes washed out by the light but as he glanced at her face his breath caught in his throat.
Her tan skin was unblemished by time or toil, perfect lips below a

dainty nose that would be of envy to any noble's daughter. But those Eyes. He knew those eyes, but yet he didn't. They stared into him like they could guess his inner most thoughts. But he also saw them a wariness he could recognize. It did not surprise him to see her long pointed ears peeking out from dark locks of hair that fell past her waist. Unmistakable, like her eyes.
He breathed out the words hardly before he knew he'd done it "An Elf?"
Immediately the set of Tarhan's jaw made it just as clear as the look in her eyes that he had caused offense. Before Sylas could ameliorate the situation, Queen Kasirda Spoke with a cutting tone, "As I said, differences aside. You will leave immediately. Sylas, you will accompany Tarhan as the Queen's Champion and serve as her protection in this kingdom, Cinderoacks and whatever else foul lands you must travel through . The importance of this matter is paramount. The Day of the Dawn-Shyrn is quick approaching and there is no room for error or dissonance. I expect you-" She said, turning to Tarhan "-to show us the power of a sorceress of the new-century." And returning her gaze to Sylas, "And you to go forth and reclaim her, for the honour of this kingdom and for all our very lives. If she does not return before the alignment" she said, gesturing to the bands of silver slowly orbiting their visiting moon, "Then the last millennia of hard won freedom will come to an end". Her last words were spoken like a promise.
Sylas could be a hard man and he could be brave but question in his gut wouldn't let him right now. Right now he needed to know for sure. Sylas Turned from Tarhan to the Queen.
"Your Majesty, what is this search you are sending us to undertake? Who is so crucial to the Kingdom?"
To you?
With a bleak laugh the Queen turned back to him. Lit from behind she looked ethereal, like the ghosts of the Last Kingdom had their hands on her already.
"My young and witless knight, how can you not have guessed? You will travel to the ends of the earth if you must and you will go with haste, because if you do not find my daughter, the Dawn-Shyrn of the Age and princess of the kingdom, we are all doomed to die in flames. So get out of my Castle and prepare yourself."

And Sylas couldn’t tell if she looked ruthless or remorseful as she said, “for I task you to slay the Great Dragon of Jaxthabrayn”.
Sylas’ fears were confirmed.
There was no way he could kill a dragon, and live to tell the tale.

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